has mounted a spirited fightback, taking on the NDA juggernaut with determination, addressing more than a hundred public meetings.

Amid these two formidable protagonists, Nitish is quietly going the extra mile to ensure he doesn't end up in the 'also-ran' category. As of May 20, he had addressed 54 public meetings and conducted six roadshows, in a relentless if not desperate drive to remain a key player in Bihar's political theatre.

'Diminishing' Brand

The speculation about his diminishing brand value only got a fillip with the surfacing of images of him dwarfed in the company of Modi during his May 12 roadshow in Patna. Notably, the Bihar CM was seen holding a cutout of the BJP poll symbol—the *kamal* (lotus). Observers point to the CM's apparent discomfort and compulsion in this scenario. The day after, owing to an officially stated illness, Nitish had to cancel all his programmes. One of these was on May 14, the day Modi filed his nomination in Varanasi. But it added to the intrigue. Tejashwi described the absence as an indication that the CM's blessings were with him, subtly underscoring the perceived distance between Nitish and the ruling BJP.

There is also no dearth of writers eager to pen a swansong for Nitish after the Lok Sabha polls. "Nitish Kumar is a unique case, a survivor par excellence, but someone with increasingly declining relevance now," says N.K. Choudhary, a retired professor and political commentator. Politicians from across the board—sections of his alliance partners and opponents alike—are also joining the chorus, freely speculating about his political longevity. Stories of his forgetfulness—such as saying *char hazaar* (4,000) instead of *char sau* (400) regarding the NDA's target—and the erosion of his political capital due to frequent U-turns have circulated widely.

However, those close to Nitish claim to have received very positive feedback from the first five phases, asserting that his vote bank remains intact. "He is someone who never had a simple majority of his own and yet remained central to every government formation in Bihar for almost two decades, which is an indication of not just the politician's adaptability but also his across-the-board acceptance," explains Choudhary.

AMID THE TALKS ABOUT NITISH'S DIMINISHING BRAND VALUE, IMAGES SURFACED OF HIM APPEARING DWARFED NEAR PM MODI. IT ONLY AIDED THE OPPOSITION'S ATTACKS

Targeting the Core

At Siwan's Pachrukhi, Nitish took the mic for his 15-minute speech. He touched upon his initiatives that provided 50 per cent reservation for women in panchayats and urban local bodies, raised their quota in government jobs to 35 per cent, and gave cycles to school-going girls to increase education levels, which in turn led to a sharp decline in fertility rates.

To outsiders, a large part of Nitish's speech—focusing on education, fertility rate, reservation and empowerment—may have sounded like something of a NITI Aayog project. However, those familiar with him reveal a clever strategy underneath. Like in previous elections, women are once again voting in large numbers in Bihar. In the first four phases, they outnumbered their male counterparts by almost seven percentage points. Nitish has his hopes pinned on them. "His core support base, including women, is still largely intact," says Choudhary, warning that "they may start looking for options the moment it becomes clear that neither the BJP nor the RJD will accept his leadership in 2025. This is natural; every evolution is followed by decline."

However, it's not just cold statistics and empowerment that Nitish is talking of in his speeches. At Pachrukhi, the CM also switched gears and directly addressed a younger group among the crowd, who were demanding a high school. "*Arre bachcha sab, dhyan se suno na. High school vagairah e sab hoga. Chinta mat karo* (Children, listen carefully. High school etc. will be built. Don't worry)," he said, smilingly unleashing an elderly rap on the knuckles of a noisy section of the crowd, eliciting an even more rapturous response from them.

Also, unlike the somewhat over-the-top belligerence seen in his April

HOW NITISH

STRENGTHS

- Known as the architect of Bihar's turnaround story, the 'Sushasan Babu' who built roads, delivered electricity, and established the rule of law
- Has a strong following among women, who credit him for their empowerment with 35% quota in jobs and 50% in panchayat and local bodies
- Nitish's committed constituency of a large section of EBCs, Kurmis and Mahadalits has never deserted him
- A section of voters who shy away from the RJD invariably votes for Nitish and the BJP